

A FREE DM PROCEDURE · LONG ISLAND DUNGEON MASTER

THERE IS NO RULE FOR THAT

For the three seconds after a player tries something the book does not cover.

Six steps · five costs · six worked rulings · system-agnostic (SRD 5.1)

A procedure for the three seconds after a player tries something the book does not cover.

THE PROBLEM THIS FIXES

A player says “I want to kick the brazier into the oil.”

There is no rule for kicking a brazier into oil. You know roughly what should happen. You also know that four people are watching you, that the fight has a rhythm you are about to break, and that whatever comes out of your mouth in the next three seconds becomes law at your table forever. So you say the thing DMs say. “Uh, roll... athletics? Fifteen.” Then they roll a 9, you say “it doesn’t work,” and the scene dies right there on the table.

That is the failure. Not the number you picked. The number barely matters. What killed it is that a player reached for the world with both hands and the world did not move.

I have been running games for 30+ years and I still get this wrong when I am tired. What fixed it for me was not getting better at improvising. It was having a procedure, so that the tired version of me is still running the good version’s ruling.

This is that procedure. Six steps, a way to pick the number, the five things a failure is allowed to cost, and six rulings you are going to need at your next session, worked all the way through.

No stat blocks. Nothing to convert. It runs in fifth edition and it runs in whatever old-school thing you play on the side.

It is free and the whole thing is below.



THE PROCEDURE

1. SAY IT BACK

Repeat the attempt in plain words before you rule on it.

“So you’re kicking the brazier off its stand, and you want the coals to land in the oil slick.”

This costs you two seconds and it is the highest-value habit in this document. Half of all bad rulings are the DM answering a question the player did not ask. The player pictured knocking the brazier sideways into the pool at their feet. You pictured them punting a hundred pounds of hot iron across the room. You were about to set a DC for the wrong action.

It also buys you thinking time without the table watching you think, which is the whole reason DMs rush this.

2. DECIDE WHETHER IT NEEDS A ROLL AT ALL

Three answers, and only one of them involves dice.

It just works. The character is competent, the action is reasonable, nothing interesting happens if they fail. Kicking an unsecured brazier over is a thing a person can do. Say yes. Move on.

It just does not work. Not because they rolled badly, but because the fiction says no. The brazier is bolted to the floor. Tell them that, tell them now, and let them spend their turn on something else. A DM who lets a player burn a turn discovering an impossibility is stealing from them.

It is a roll. Only when failure is more interesting than automatic success.

Most improvised asks are the first one and get rolled anyway. That is the second-biggest problem after step five. Every unnecessary roll you call is a chance for the story to stop for no reason. If you cannot name what is interesting about the failure, you do not have a roll, you have a habit.

3. NAME THE ABILITY FIRST, THE SKILL SECOND

The ability is what is actually being tested. The skill is whether they trained for it.

Strength holds the door. Athletics is why this person is good at holding doors. Charisma talks the guard down. Persuasion is the training; Intimidation is a different training aimed at the same ability. When a player asks “can I use Deception for this,” they are asking the wrong question and it is not their fault, because the sheet lists the skills and buries the abilities.

Pick the ability from the fiction. Then ask if any of their proficiencies apply, and be generous about it, because generosity here is free and it makes the character sheet mean something.

4. SET THE NUMBER FROM THE LADDER

Four numbers. Ten, thirteen, fifteen, eighteen.

- **10** is a thing a competent person does most of the time.
- **13** is a real attempt that a trained person makes reliably and an untrained one does not.
- **15** is hard. Expertise, or a good plan, or luck standing in for both.
- **18** is a story they tell afterward.

Do not invent a 14. I know why you want to. You want the number to encode exactly how hard you think it is, and 14 feels more honest than 13. It is not more honest, it is just less usable, and by session three you will have a table where the DCs are 12, 14, 16, and 17 and nobody, including you, can feel the difference between them. Four rungs is a ladder. Nine rungs is noise.

If the situation deserves credit, do not move the number. Give advantage. That is what advantage is for, and players can feel it in a way they cannot feel a two-point DC adjustment.

5. SAY THE COST OUT LOUD, BEFORE THE ROLL

This is the one. If you take a single thing from this page, take this.

“Roll Strength. Fifteen. Miss it and the brazier goes over the far edge instead, and you lose your light.”

The player now knows what they are buying. They can back out. They can spend a resource. They can ask if there is a better angle. And when the die comes up 9, nothing has to be improvised in the ugliest possible moment, because you already said what a 9 buys.

A roll with an unstated cost is how you end up saying “it doesn’t work.” You did not decide the cost in advance, so under pressure your brain reached for the only cost that requires no invention, which is nothing happening. Nothing happening is not a consequence. It is the absence of one.

State the cost first and you will never say “it doesn’t work” again, because you will have already said something better.

6. MOVE THE WORLD EITHER WAY

Whatever the die said, something is different now.

They made it: the oil catches and the two cultists on the far side lose their cover. They missed it: the brazier goes over the edge and the room is darker than it was. Both of those are the scene continuing. Neither of them is “you’re still standing where you were.”

If your ruling ends with the board in exactly the state it started in, you did not make a ruling. You paused the game and then unpaused it.



WHAT A FAILURE IS ALLOWED TO COST

Here is the part nobody tells you. Everybody says “fail forward.” Almost nobody says what the failures are made of. Five things, and you should be reaching for a different one each time.

1. It works, but it costs. Time, a resource, position, or noise. They get the door open. It takes a full minute and everything in the hall heard it. This is the default and it is the one you will use most.

2. It works, but not all of it. They kick the brazier over. Some coals reach the oil, so there is fire, but it is a line of fire between two people instead of the pool going up at once. Partial success is not a consolation prize. It is usually the most interesting outcome available.

3. It does not work, and now they know why. The information is the payment. The brazier is chained to the floor, and the chain is new, which means somebody who lives here was worried about exactly this. Now they know something about the room and about whoever prepared it.

4. It does not work, and something else moves. The attempt eats the turn and the clock ticks. The guard rounds the corner. The ritual gets one line further. Use this when the pressure is the point and the fight has a timer.

5. It works, and that is the problem. My favorite, and the one that separates a table you remember from one you do not. The oil catches. All of it. The fire is now between the party and the door, and the thing they came to rescue is on the wrong side. They got exactly what they asked for. It is a disaster. Nobody at that table will forget it.

That last one has a rule attached: only use it when the player got what they asked for, never as a punishment for asking. If they roll well and you hand them a catastrophe, you have taught them not to try things, which is the opposite of everything on this page. The success has to genuinely be the thing they wanted. The world just turns out to be more flammable than they estimated.



SIX RULINGS YOU WILL NEED AT YOUR NEXT SESSION

These are the improvised asks that come up constantly. Here is how each one runs.

Where a ruling below says **cost 2** or **cost 4**, that is the numbered menu from the section above. Cost 1 is “it works, but it costs.” Cost 5 is “it works, and that is the problem.”

“I SHOVE HIM OFF THE LEDGE.”

What most tables do: the DM picks a DC out of the air.

The ruling: do not. Shoving is already in the rules, and this is the most common miss on the list. It is a contested check, their Athletics against the target’s Athletics or Acrobatics with the target choosing which, and it costs one attack instead of a whole turn. The rule is better than anything you would have invented, and using it means the fighter who invested in Athletics gets paid.

When you do need a number: when they are shoving something that does not have a stat block, or shoving with an improvised lever, or shoving a creature two sizes larger, which the rules say they cannot do at all. Then it is DC 15 and cost 2, they push it half as far as they wanted.

The general lesson, and it is the biggest one here: before you invent a ruling, spend one second asking whether the game already has a rule. Improvised adjudication is for the gaps. Most tables improvise on top of rules that were already sitting right there.

“I TRY TO TALK HIM DOWN. MID-FIGHT.”

What most tables do: DC 20, or a flat no, because letting one Persuasion check end a combat feels like it breaks something.

The ruling: it does not break anything, but you have to be honest about what is being asked. Talking down a creature that is winning, has no reason to stop, and has never met these people is not a hard check. It is impossible, and step two says tell them so.

Talking down a bandit who has watched two friends drop, who was in it for money, and who now has an obvious exit is a real attempt. Charisma. DC 13. Cost 4, it takes the turn, and the ritual gets another line further.

What you actually need: the creature has to have a reason to stop that exists independently of the roll. Fear, money, orders it dislikes, a wounded friend. If you cannot name the reason before they roll, the answer is no and the roll is theater.

The good version: let it work partially. Cost 2. He stops fighting. He will not help and he will not talk, he just backs toward the door and watches. Now there is a person in the room with opinions, which is worth more than a corpse.

“CAN I USE THAT SPELL TO DO THE THING IT DOES NOT SAY?”

What most tables do: yes to everything, which erases the classes that paid for those effects, or no to everything, which teaches casters to stop reading their own spell list.

The ruling: two questions, in this order.

First, does it do something the spell’s actual effect can obviously produce? *Thaumaturgy* makes a booming voice and rattles doors. Using it to make a stone corridor sound occupied is fair. Using it to shatter a lock is not, because the spell does not break things.

Second, does it replace a chunk of somebody else’s contribution? Using *prestidigitation* to clean a bloodstain off a coat is fine, and it is printed right there in the spell. Forging a seal with it is the harder call, because the spell does let you put a mark on an object, so a player quoting it at you is not wrong. Read the rest of the entry before you answer: the mark lasts an hour and it is a mark, not embossed wax. So the ruling is that the spell gets them a convincing copy that will not survive the night, which is a real answer instead of a no, and the Forgery kit somebody at the table bought still does the permanent version better.

If it passes both, say yes, set a DC 13 for the execution, and say what a miss costs before they roll. Cost 1 usually: it works, it just takes long enough that someone hears. If it fails the second question, say “yes, and roll it, but the rogue’s kit would do this better,” which is a yes that still protects the rogue.

Say yes more than feels safe. A caster reading their own spells for an angle is the single best behavior at a table. Ruling against it once will stop it for a year.

“I SEARCH THE ROOM.”

What most tables do: roll Perception, read them whatever the DC allows.

The ruling: this is not a roll, it is a missing question, and the fix is one sentence. “Where are you looking?”

Not a gotcha. It is genuinely faster. “The desk” gets an answer immediately, because you know what is in the desk. “The whole room” cannot be answered without a die, so the die is doing your job.

If they name a place and the letter is in it and finding it is not interesting, just give it to them. No roll. If somebody hid that letter on purpose, that is Investigation against the number the hider earned, cost 4 on a miss because searching a room properly is slow and whatever is in this house is still moving around in it. Perception is the other thing: noticing what the room tells them without being asked.

When there is genuinely nothing: say so out loud. “You can search it, and I’ll tell you now, there’s nothing hidden in here.” You lose nothing. Tables that trust you not to waste their time will search the rooms that matter.

“I SET IT ON FIRE.”

What most tables do: either fire solves the encounter instantly, or the DM decides everything in the dungeon is damp.

The ruling: fire is always the answer because fire is genuinely a good idea, and a DM who keeps ruling it down is training the table out of thinking. Let it work. Control the timing instead.

Fire needs three things and you get to decide which one is missing: fuel, air, and time. A wooden door burns. It burns in about ten minutes, which in a dungeon with anything moving in it is forever. And the smoke goes somewhere. Whatever is in that somewhere now knows.

The ruling as run: no check to start it, that is just a torch and a reasonable person. The check is whether they can do it fast enough to matter. DC 15 with the oil they are carrying, cost 1, it works and it takes the round and the light is now visible down the whole corridor.

Never rule that the thing does not burn unless it genuinely does not burn. Rule that burning it takes long enough to be a decision.

“MY CHARACTER WOULD KNOW THIS. THERE IS NO SKILL FOR IT.”

A sailor asked about the tide. A former soldier asked whether that formation is a real one. A blacksmith's kid asked if that weld is fresh.

What most tables do: Intelligence check, DC something, and the sailor fails the tide question in front of everybody.

The ruling: do not roll. Tell them. Background knowledge is not a check, it is a fact the character walked in with, and the entire reason the player wrote “sailor” on the sheet was to be the person who knows about tides. Making them roll for their own concept is the single most common way to make a background feel worthless.

The roll is for the edge case: what a sailor knows and a very good sailor knows more of. Give them the base fact free, then offer the check for the extra. “You know the tide turns around dawn. Wisdom, thirteen, if you want to know how much draft that hull needs.” Cost 3 on a miss, they are not sure, and being unsure is real information for a person deciding whether to risk a boat.

This one is not really about adjudication. It is about the fact that a character sheet is a set of promises, and every time you roll for a promise, you make it slightly less true.

THE CARD

Everything above, in the shape you can keep open.

The six steps

1. Say the attempt back in plain words.
2. Just works? Just does not? Or a roll? Roll only if failure is interesting.
3. Ability from the fiction. Skill if they trained for it. Be generous.
4. 10 easy, 13 real, 15 hard, 18 a story. Never a 14. Credit becomes advantage, not a lower number.
5. Say the cost out loud before the die moves.
6. Move the world either way.

The five costs

1. It works, but it costs. (Time, resource, position, noise.)
2. It works, but not all of it.
3. It does not work, and now they know why.
4. It does not work, and the clock ticks.
5. It works, and that is the problem. (Only ever on a success they earned.)

The three questions when you are stuck

- Is there already a rule for this?
- What does a failure change?
- If nothing changes on a failure, why is this a roll?



RUNNING THIS IN OTHER SYSTEMS

Nothing here is fifth edition. Steps one, two, three, five and six are system-agnostic on their face.

Step four is the only piece with a number in it. In a system with a different curve, keep the shape and change the rungs: four fixed difficulties, spaced far enough apart that your table can feel the gap. Old-school games running a d20 roll-under can use the ability score itself as the target and take a penalty for hard, a bonus for easy, which is the same ladder with the arithmetic flipped. In dice-pool systems the rungs are the pool, not a number.

The five costs are the part that travels best. Games built around partial success have that menu in their core loop already; games without it get most of the benefit from a DM who has read the list once.



IF THIS WAS USEFUL

I write these because the free stuff is the stuff I would have wanted at year two, and because a DM with a procedure runs a better table than a DM with a better memory.

Get the DM's Field Kit. It is the free signup gift, and it is the print-and-go version of this kind of thing.

Take a free adventure. *The Night Watchman* is a complete solo adventure you can play in a browser tonight, and *Where the Road Ends* is a free Table Keeper if you would rather have something to run for a group.

The storefront has the paid Adventure Keepers, if you want the full thing with the tools built in.

The Bi-Weekly One-Shot is where the paid adventures land, every other Wednesday.



Long Island Dungeon Master. The adventures are mine. 30+ years of real tables.

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